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USING DESIGN APPROACHES FOR FINE-GRAINED POLICY DESIGN

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INTRODUCTION

This paper discusses a design-led approach to socially-based solutions for municipal-level social issues. Three examples are presented showing an alternative approach to policy design, a field in flux.

Social changes and challenges to liberal democracy require more participative policy making (Ferro et al., 2013) especially with regard to "the elaboration and discussion of solutions to societal problems" (Knill & Tosun, 2020). "Policy design involves the deliberate and conscious attempt to define policy goals and connect them to instruments or tools expected to realise those objectives" (Howlett, et al., 2015). Until recent times "policy formulation [was] often the realm of the experts, the 'hidden participants' " (Sidney, 2017). A proposed alternative is decentralization. An example of this is a co-design approach (Kimbell & Bailey, 2017). But decentralised policy making "requires the involvement of stakeholders as active participants into the policy process at different levels of societal organization" (Pahl-Wostl, 2002). Policy design is also complicated by the co-occurrence of systematic processes and more contingent, situational logics (Howlett et al., 2014).

Policy making runs into a difficulty "creating practice tensions that increase the complexity of local service systems" (Keevers et al., 2008) and also when the generalities of policy meet the specifics of locality (Herriott, 2018). This arises from the "the "value-action gap" regarding the tensions due to an information deficit in participation in deliberation (Blake, 1999). Blake argued for emphasis "on the negotiation of partnerships that are more

sensitive to local diversity, and which involve a more equitable distribution of responsibility between different environmental stakeholders".

Decentralisation has been one of the developments in policy-making (Bednar, 2008). This was seen in the form a shift from hierarchical to network-forms (Ferlie et al., 2011), a shift to design orientation (Howlett et al., (2015) and a shift to open-policy making (PolyVisu, 2024). Examples include Karlson et al. (2017) and Malfait et al. (2018) concerning policy in health-care settings. From another direction, a body of literature in design research focuses on design for society and social change (Apaydın and Subaşı, 2024; Baumann et al., 2017; Bray et al., 2022, Winschiers-Theophilus et al., 2012 and Fono et al., 2024). Kimbell & Bailey discuss prototyping in policy design (2017). Fono et al. (2024) discuss (the lack of) co-design examples in that field.

In a report on the current debates and future directions of design and policy, Kimbell et al., (2023) state that there has been a significant design turn in government and policy-making, across the UK, Europe, and globally in the last two decades in the form of more adoption of design-related approaches. The rise of innovation and policy labs within government reflects the increasing integration and institutionalization of design practices in governance. Despite this, there seems to be a tension between design and policy arising from inherent differences in priorities, approaches, and timescales. Design often focuses on human-centered, creative, and iterative approaches. It aims for flexible, innovative solutions tailored to specific contexts (Kimbell and Bailey, 2017). Policymaking emphasizes scalability, standardization, and compliance within legal, economic, and social framework, making them slow to adapt changing needs. In contrast, design often focuses on context-specific interventions. Bridging these requires mechanisms to adapt local insights to broader frameworks. Design processes are typically iterative and fast-paced, whereas policymaking is deliberative and slow due to the need for consensus, regulation, and stability. The tension between design and policy underscores the importance of creating bridges between the granular, human-centric lens of design and the macro-level, systemic focus of policy. Addressing this requires an iterative, inclusive, and adaptive approach to integrating local knowledge into broader frameworks. We ask then how design tries to fill the gap between coarse-grained and rigid policies and the fine-grained particularities of the personal, local and regional. What tension exists between policy and design? What specific methods can integrate design participants' voices?

CASES

The first project is Academy of Life (based in Vienna, Austria) connects citizens, knowledge institutions such as libraries and museums with local policy makers to formulate needs and wishes for inclusive public support throughout the life course. The background to this is a

still rigid understanding of ageing based on binary categories of old and young, which fails to recognise the flexible transitions during life stages. A rigid understanding of life-courses also affects support services orientated towards age cohorts, such as clubs for senior citizens to prevent social isolation or support for young people with mental health problems. To show how views on ageing are reinforced and mitigated by policy and the resulting services, the project uses an exhibition/design game in libraries and museums for co-speculation. This public statement seeks to stimulate debate about reshaping images of ageing and uses the game to support exploration of personal, interpersonal and systemic policy relationships. Design ethnography is used to explore the practices of people in life transitions and their coping mechanisms. Co-creation with citizens and with policy makers aims to identify what a preferred future might look like inspiring new formats of support. The project thus uses research through design to break down silos, tap into knowledge of lived diversity and identify opportunities for contemporary interpretations for services and policies.

The second case, Youth Centred Policy Design deals with young people and policy making. In Denmark there has been a tendency for professionals to define and make the content for policy affecting the young. Even if there is youth stakeholder input it typically consists mainly of high-performing children and young people (Li, 2020). The potential of co-design and the hurdles in this underdeveloped field are discussed by Buchanan (2020). The municipality of Ringsted, Denmark, wanted to do things differently and avoid policy that ended up shelved. A team of youth-counsellors gathered input from 8000 participants, 0-25 years old, representing 80% of the district´s youth cohort. They collaborated with , providing insights in engaging and involving children and young people in the formation of such a policy. This included child- and youth-centred design methods (Feder, 2020; Christiansen, 2022), such as adjustments of play probes, co-creation workshops and young-to-child interviews to fit the targe group and context. One example was adjusting play probes for 9-11 years old, with content about childhood in Ringsted. The probes were introduced as “mind-bags” that a friendly alien had provided to the children to learn about their lives. The children were very invested in filling out the mind-bags and sharing their insights.
The data was analysed and then presented to the participants to ensure it was not biased or reworded into generic terms by the adult-perspectives. As well as creating a stronger policy for the municipality, one the children and young people can identify with, it showed a learning potential as the children and young people got curious about the democratic processes, and this reflected on the coming topics dealt with both in the kindergartens and schools involved.

The third case, 4D Picture, is European research project about including patients, relatives and clinicians into a shared decision-making process about cancer treatment. To understand and involve all stakeholders it follows a methodology (Griffioen-Van Dijk, 2023) to map the treatment steps, stakeholders and experiences. This is to focus on patients’ and relatives’ experiences not only the factual treatment plan. In Denmark, cancer treatment follows a national plan and policy. But healthcare is organised regionally. Information about

treatment and supportive care is provided by a little-used national app, *MyHospital*. It is designed regionally and is not adjustable to the individual patient's needs. Through a service exploration approach involving local stakeholders it was found that relevant offers for patients and relative were delivered locally. People thus by-pass the regional system, wanting something mirroring the local focus of offers as well as something controlled locally, by the hospital or doctor. Through co-creation workshops with stakeholders but no policy makers involved (because it by-passes the regional level) the idea of a more customizable information solution is being developed. It supports individual needs and goes beyond the regional support which amounted to unfilterable lists. 4D Picture addresses a local situation were the policy system lags. Potential design solutions can´t be integrated into the regional app. A new app solution is being developed but is again designed and developed on regional level and through external partners. Clinicians and health care providers recognise and agree with a need for a more local solution. There is a conflict between patients' needs, clinicians and designers' professional standpoint and the policy and decision makers

RESEARCH STAGES

The successive stages of the research are 1) to elaborate on the shifts in policy making away from the central and national 2) examine research in design-led policy making and 3) analyse the three projects to show how design led policy and delivery work can close the gap between the national and regional, the general and the context dependence. It would seem design research and policy design research are converging and grappling with the same scale of problem from different directions, both using the term *design* but in different senses. The convergence of these two fields represents a growing acknowledgment that designing for systems and designing for people are deeply interconnected. While policy design research brings a macro-level perspective, design research brings the tools and methods to engage with micro-level realities. Together, they offer a powerful framework for tackling complex, wicked problems that span multiple scales and dimensions. By leveraging their respective strengths, these fields can collaborate to create policies that are not only systemic and strategic but also grounded in the lived experiences of the people they aim to serve.

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